

100 Days of Linux - Day 011

Title: Reading Files with cat

Today's Goal

Learn how to view the contents of text files using the **cat** command.

Why This Matters

Developers and data engineers frequently inspect configuration files, SQL scripts, logs, and source code directly from the terminal.

Command of the Day: cat

Syntax: cat filename

Explanation: Displays the contents of one or more text files.

Common Examples:

cat notes.txt

cat file1.txt file2.txt

Beginner Lesson

Until now you've created files with **touch**, but those files were empty. Today you'll learn how to display file contents. To practice, first create a file using your terminal editor or by redirecting simple text into a file if you already know how, then use **cat** to read it.

Practice Questions

1. Create a file named `welcome.txt` and add the text 'Welcome to Linux' using any method you know, then display it with `cat`.
2. Create two files named `python.txt` and `sql.txt`, add one line of text to each, then display both files using a single `cat` command.
3. Display the contents of `README.md` from your practice folder (if it exists).
4. Navigate to a different directory and use `cat` to display a text file stored there.
5. Display your current working directory after completing the tasks.

Hints

Create or edit files first, then use cat to read them. If a file doesn't exist, create it before displaying it.

Mini Challenge

Create a folder named `notes`. Inside it create three text files with different messages. Use one `cat` command to display all three files together.

Common Mistakes

Trying to use `cat` on a directory instead of a file.

Did You Know?

The name 'cat' comes from 'concatenate', because it can join and display multiple files.

Pro Tip

Use cat for small files. For very large files, you'll learn better tools like less later.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: cat welcome.txt

Q2: cat python.txt sql.txt

Q3: cat README.md

Q4: cd && cat filename

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create five text files with short notes and practice viewing each one using cat.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn the head command to display only the first few lines of a file.